maintain some self-correcting mechanisms to protect the truth even from the will of the majority.

For example, during the 2002–3 debate over whether to invade Iraq in the wake of the September 11 attacks, the Bush administration claimed that Saddam Hussein was developing weapons of mass destruction and that the Iraqi people were eager to establish an American-style democracy and would welcome the Americans as liberators. These arguments carried the day. In October 2002 the elected representatives of the American people in Congress voted overwhelmingly to authorise the invasion. The resolution passed with a 296 to 133 majority (69 per cent) in the House of Representatives and a 77 to 23 majority (77 per cent) in the Senate.[6] In the early days of the war in March 2003, polls found that the elected representatives were indeed in tune with the mass of voters and that 72 per cent of American citizens supported the invasion.[7] The will of the American people was clear.

But the truth turned out to be different from what the government said and what the majority believed. As the war progressed, it became evident that Iraq had no weapons of mass destruction and that many Iraqis had no wish to be ‘liberated’ by the Americans or to establish a democracy. By August 2004 another poll found that 67 per cent of Americans believed that the invasion was based on incorrect assumptions. As the years went by, most Americans acknowledged that the decision to invade was a catastrophic mistake.[8]

In a democracy the majority has every right to make momentous decisions like starting wars, and that includes the right to make momentous errors. But the majority should at least acknowledge its own fallibility and protect the freedom of minorities to hold and publicise unpopular views, which might turn out to be correct.

As another example, consider the case of a charismatic leader who is accused of corruption. His loyal supporters obviously wish these accusations to be false. But even if most voters support the leader, their desires should not prevent judges from investigating the accusations and getting to the truth. As with the justice system, so also with science. A majority of voters might deny the reality of climate change, but they should not have the power to dictate scientific truth or to prevent scientists from exploring and publishing inconvenient facts. Unlike parliaments,